

A SENSE OF VALUES

To be truly rich, regardless of his fortune or lack of it, a man must live by his own values. If those values are not personally meaningful, then no amount of money gained can hide the emptiness of a life without them.

I have known entirely too many people who spend their lives trying to be what others want them to be and doing what others expect them to do. They force themselves into patterns of behavior which have been established for—and by—people with personalities entirely different from their own. Seeking to conform to those patterns, they dissolve into grotesque, blurred mirror images as they obliterate their individuality to imitate others. Rootless, dissatisfied, they strive frantically—and most often vainly—to find their own identities within the constricting limits of an existence alien to their natures, instincts and innate desires.

"I wanted to be a writer. My father refused to hear of it and insisted I go to law school and become an attorney. I make a good living now, but I'm bored and restless . . ."

"I'd like to sell my business and buy a ranch somewhere, but my wife won't let me because she's afraid it would mean a loss of income and prestige . . ."

"There's nothing I hate more than suburban living. I'd much rather have an apartment in the city, but all the other executives in my firm have homes in the suburbs . . ."

"I feel trapped, as though I'm caught up in a pointless rat race. I really don't like or enjoy my work, but I don't know what else I could do and still make as much money as I'm making now . . ."

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I've heard such statements as these made with ever-increasing frequency in recent years. Essentially, they are expressions of personal discontent—and even defeat—but they also reflect a constantly growing social illness of our time.